Choosing by Habitus

Multi-Case Study of Families & Schools in the Context of School Choice

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Linking Schools and Families in the Process of Choosing a School

Abstract

This qualitative multi-case study explores the dynamics among schools and families during the process of choosing a school through a social class lens and includes narrative data gathered from families and school professionals in four schools within one local commune of Chile. Findings illustrate that families and schools enacted social class through their habitus, Bourdieu's concept of socialized norms or tendencies (and values) that guide behavior and thinking (Wacquant, 2005). Three types of habitus emerge: historical, aspirational, and survival. In the case of families, habitus is expressed in the process of choosing a school. In the case of schools, staff members activate elements of their habitus in the ways they perceive and face the process of enrollment and recruitment of students. The study illuminates the ways in which social class moderates school choice by affecting not only families but also schools. Because schools have preferences in the type of families they seek and wish to retain, they reinforce the habitus of the families.
The relationship between institutions and families points to the complex relationships among social class, social capital, identity, and educational institutions in a setting where choosing among different educational options is normative. Conclusions raise questions about; the role of habitus in the process of choosing a school, the influence of social class, through habitus, by impacting the ways families choose schools and schools recruit families; and the contribution of schools in social reproduction.



Studying the Process of Choosing a School

The examination of school choice in this study, understands it as a sociocultural process, rather than a particular event, and that decisions/choice persist even after a child matriculates at a particular school. This definition also implies that in the process of choosing a school, both, families and schools, are engaging; thus, there is not a process only circumscribed to families.

The purpose of this study is to come to understand how families and schools enact social class and social capital, during the process of choosing a school. The research questions are:

- How do families enact social class during the process of choosing a school?
- How do schools enact social class during the process of choosing a school?

The Context of the Study: A middle size commune of Chile

The Chilean Education System

The Chilean educational system includes 12 years of compulsory education. Primary education is from ages 6 to 13, and secondary education is from ages 14 to 17. Both public and private alternatives exist for all educational levels (UNESCO/IBE, 2010).
Chile has operated with a nationwide voucher system in a market-driven educational system for more than three decades and it represents a unique case to understand market-based reforms in education.
Unlike other voucher systems in the world, Chile's voucher system offers preferential conditions for private subsidized schools. It allows for-profit organizations, pupil selection mechanisms, and the collection of fees from families. These policy mechanisms are key components of the structural design of the education system, and thus, modulate the ways in which school choice is implemented at national level. Those mechanisms affect deeply the ways in which families and schools perceived and face the process of choosing a school.
In this context, students and their parents became economic actors, with the latter being in charge of deciding and selecting the "best" educational offer, within the logic of market. Parents and particularly their ability to choose were declared paramount to the proper performance of the educational "market."



Literature Review

The themes of school-family relationships and school choice in conjunction are critical, but still underexplored areas of research to understand the intersection between schools and families in the context of school choice. This implies breaking with the traditional focus either on schools or families are separate entities in order to prioritize in the interrelationship between them. A premise in this argument is that any comprehension of one actor without the other limits our understanding of the complexities of school choice and its role in the reproduction of inequality.

Research Design and Methodology

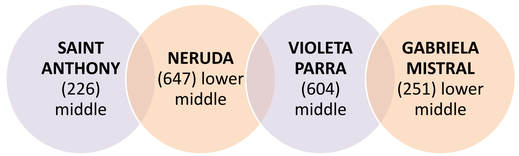
Research Design

I employ a multiple-case study in order to explore families and schools enactments of social class in the process of choosing. Case studies are focused on questions of "why" and "how" and are ideal for explanatory questions, lack of control over the event, and a focus on contemporary events (Yin, 2009). Furthermore, multiple-case studies allow exploring similarities and differences among cases, enriching the understanding of the phenomenon. Although this aspect might lead to the possibility for generalizing findings, this is not a major goal of the study.

Research Methods

This study utilizes four levels of sampling. The first level is the selection of commune (a territorial area that represents the smallest geographical and political-administrative unity in the Chilean territory) the second level of sampling involves the selection of neighborhoods within the commune, the third level is the selection of schools, and finally the fourth level is the selection of participants within each school. Four school institutions from the same commune in two different neighborhoods will be chosen as cases for this multiple case study. The sampling method used is a non-probability sampling procedure because in each level the sampling was chosen following a set of predetermined criteria aligned with the purposes of the research.

The Four Schools Cases



Data Collection and Analysis

Data collection strategies focused on parents and school staff. And they were: semi-structured interviews (36), focus groups (10), observations, and document analysis.
Data analysis included an overall strategy and specific analytic techniques to be applied in two moments: a within-case and a cross-case analysis (Eisenhardt, 1989; Yin, 2009).
Data analysis procedures included transcribing a subsection of the material and elaborating the code book. A second round of analysis involved listing and codifying the audios for all the rest of material through Nvivo software.

Habitus: Historical, Aspirational, and Survival

The Emergence of Habitus

Participants both from families and from schools consistently talked about features that Bourdieu would have included in the concept of habitus as aspects of their perspectives and practices.
Families and schools shared similar elements organized in a common narrative among school-cases referred to three different habitus that were identified as: **historical habitus, aspirational habitus, and survival habitus**. These three types of habitus expressed a particular way in which families and schools enacted social class in the process of choosing a school.

Habitus by School cases	Families' dispositions	Schools' dispositions
Historical Neruda & Violeta Parra	We looked for a school that reinforces our past, and offers a strong legacy	We looked for families from our network that trust in ourselves
Aspirational Saint Anthony	We looked for a school that allows us to get symbolic social mobility	We looked for families interested on symbolic class distinctions
Survival Gabriela Mistral	We looked for a school where there are vacancies and based on practical criteria	We do not look for families and we accept all students we receive

Conclusions and Implications

- This study disclosure the richness of Bourdieu's concept of habitus to explore the process of choosing a school, and how habitus enriches our understanding of the role of social class in educational processes.
- Literature has extensively described how families chose schools. But to what extent schools are involved on the process of choosing a school through by investing time, resources, and energy in recruit not only students but families that are the best fit to their habitus. More empirical research in diverse settings about schools' habitus and how they might reinforce, recreate, or interrupt family' habitus would be beneficial to deepen our comprehension of school choice dynamics.

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